

The African FAST Platform Playbook

Real templates and frameworks for launching a free, ad-supported streaming platform in Africa — vendor negotiation, content licensing, and category sponsorship, drawn from an active build.

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Real templates for launching a free, ad-supported streaming (FAST) platform in Africa

By John Idani Upah, ARPA — Managing Director, Media Icons Africa, 30+ years in Nigerian broadcasting and media sales

Who This Is For

You're building — or thinking about building — a streaming platform, TV channel, or content distribution business anywhere in Africa. You've hit, or are about to hit, three walls that almost every founder in this space hits:

1. **Vendor quotes that don't fit African ad-revenue economics.** Global OTT platform vendors price for subscription markets. You need free, ad-supported, and the first quote you get almost never reflects what's actually negotiable.
2. **Content owners who don't trust platforms anymore.** Prior African streaming platforms — bank-backed, telco-backed, well-funded — burned the content ownership community with broken revenue-share promises. You're starting several steps behind zero trust, whether you caused that or not.
3. **Advertisers who don't yet have a clean way to buy pan-African reach.** The sponsorship model that works in mature FAST markets (Pluto TV, Tubi) hasn't been properly adapted and pitched for African category-exclusive buyers yet.

This playbook is not theory. It's the actual negotiation structure, deal terms, and sponsorship pitch framework used in the live build of a pan-African FAST platform — genericized so you can apply it to your own build, whatever stage you're at.

Part 1: The Vendor Negotiation Playbook

The core lesson

The first quote a global OTT vendor gives you is almost never their real floor — and it's often structured to maximize their recurring revenue, not to fit your

business model.

What actually happened

An initial vendor proposal came in at roughly \$30,000+ for Year 1, built around a premium, subscription-oriented (“SVOD-style”) platform product — priced and structured for markets where charging viewers monthly is the default assumption. For a FAST platform whose entire model depends on thin ad-revenue margins, a heavy *recurring* platform fee — dressed up as a “Year 1” number — is not a rounding error. It’s a structural threat to ever reaching profitability.

Through direct, specific pushback — not generic “can you do better on price” negotiating, but detailed technical questions — the deal was restructured to a **flat, one-time build fee**, roughly 55–60% lower than the original figure, with full source code and IP ownership transferring on final payment. No recurring platform tax.

The two moves that made the difference

Move 1 — Ask exactly how their video infrastructure generates a live stream. The specific question that unlocked the bigger savings: *“Does your platform’s own streaming engine generate the live manifest directly, or do we need to pay for separate origin/packaging infrastructure on top of your platform fee?”*

Many quotes bundle in (or quietly require) separate cloud infrastructure — origin servers, packaging, ad-decisioning — that can cost tens of thousands of dollars a year on its own, on top of the “platform fee” you were quoted. Asking this one detailed, technical question can surface — and eliminate — a major hidden recurring cost.

Move 2 — Push for a one-time build with IP transfer, not a recurring “apps manager” fee. Many vendors default to a subscription-style “apps manager” or “platform access” fee structure — meaning you never actually own the platform, you rent it indefinitely. Ask directly: *“Can we structure this as a one-time build fee, with full source code and IP ownership transferring to us on final payment, instead of an ongoing platform fee?”* Reputable vendors with genuine engineering capability can often say yes — because they’re not actually giving up much; they’re giving up recurring revenue on infrastructure you can now self-host in exchange for a clean, larger one-time payment.

Template: Milestone Payment Structure

Use this structure (or adapt the percentages) when negotiating a one-time build fee — it protects both sides and keeps the vendor incentivized through delivery:

Milestone	% of Total	Trigger
1. Sign-off	40%	Scope and contract signed
2. Core build complete	30%	Core platform functionality delivered for review
3. UAT (User Acceptance Testing) passed	20%	You’ve tested the platform end-to-end and signed off
4. Go-live + warranty period	10%	Platform is live and has run stable through an agreed

	warranty window (30 days is a reasonable ask)
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Negotiation checklist — before you sign any OTT vendor quote

- ☐ Ask if the quoted number is one-time or recurring — get this in writing, explicitly
- ☐ Ask exactly how live manifest/stream generation works, and whether separate origin/packaging infrastructure is required on top of the platform fee
- ☐ Ask whether ad-decisioning (which ad plays, to whom, when) is included, or whether you need a separate ad server — many “ad stitching” features only insert ads, they don’t manage campaigns or creative
- ☐ Request full source code and IP ownership on final payment if you’re paying a one-time fee
- ☐ Structure payment across milestones (sign-off / core build / UAT / go-live + warranty), never 100% upfront
- ☐ Ask about escrow for source code as a fallback if the vendor won’t grant IP transfer outright — and if declined, ask for read access to the source repository from the start of the project instead
- ☐ Get a clear delivery timeline in weeks, tied to the milestone structure, not a vague “a few months”
- ☐ Ask what a lower-cost self-hosted alternative for any given component would look like — you may be able to self-host what the vendor wants to charge you a recurring fee for

Part 2: The Content Licensing Deal Template

The core lesson

In markets where prior platforms have broken payment promises, the deal structure itself — not the pitch — is what earns a content owner’s trust.

The trust problem you’re inheriting

If you’re building a content platform anywhere prior platforms have promised revenue share and failed to pay reliably, you are not starting from zero trust with content owners. You are starting from *negative* trust, inherited from broken promises that had nothing to do with you. Content owners will test you accordingly — and they should.

The five fears, and the structural answer to each

Content owner’s fear	Structural answer
“I’ll hand over my work and never get paid.”	Written, contractually binding payment terms on a specific schedule (e.g. Net-45 — payment within 45 days of the period closing) — not verbal promises
“I’ll have bet my whole distribution strategy on one platform.”	Non-exclusive licensing — the content owner can license the same title elsewhere simultaneously

"I'll lose control of where my work can go."	Territory-limited licensing — scope the deal to your actual operating region (e.g. Sub-Saharan Africa only); global/international rights stay with the content owner
"Revenue share means I'm exposed to your ad-sales performance, which I can't verify."	Offer a guaranteed licence fee option where you can fund it — a fixed payment regardless of your own ad performance — even if it's a smaller amount than a best-case revenue share
"I have no way to verify any of this is real."	Go through respected industry associations, not just cold outreach — let their existing trust with their members work in your favor

Template: Two Deal Structures to Offer

Structure A — Revenue Share (lower risk to you, higher risk/upside to content owner) - Content owner receives an agreed percentage of net ad revenue generated by their titles - Non-exclusive, territory-limited to your operating region - Payment terms: Net-30 to Net-45, in writing, with a defined reporting cadence (e.g. monthly revenue report) - Best used when: you're pre-revenue or early-revenue and can't yet fund guarantees, and the content owner is willing to bet on your platform's growth

Structure B — Guaranteed Licence Fee (higher cost/risk to you, lower risk to content owner) - Fixed payment for a defined licensing period, regardless of your platform's ad performance - Same non-exclusive, territory-limited structure - Requires you to have (or raise) real capital committed upfront — be honest with yourself about whether you can actually fund this before offering it - Best used when: you're approaching content owners or associations who've been burned by revenue-share promises before, and predictability matters more to them than potential upside

Negotiation checklist — before you approach any content owner

- ☐ Decide honestly which structure (A or B, or a hybrid) you can actually fund and deliver on — don't offer guarantees you can't keep
- ☐ Put payment terms in a specific, numbered day-count (e.g. "Net-45"), not vague language like "regularly" or "promptly"
- ☐ Default to non-exclusive unless you have a specific reason (and budget) to ask for exclusivity
- ☐ Scope territory explicitly — name the countries/region, don't imply global rights you won't properly monetize
- ☐ Identify the respected industry association(s) or gatekeepers in your market and build a relationship with them before or alongside individual content owner outreach
- ☐ Prepare a one-page written summary of your terms you can leave behind — verbal pitches don't survive being repeated to a skeptical peer
- ☐ Ask directly what would make a content owner comfortable saying yes — then listen to the actual answer instead of persuading past it

Part 3: The Category-Exclusive Sponsorship Pitch

Framework

The core lesson

Advertisers don't just want reach. They want a defensible position their direct competitor can't buy their way into. Category exclusivity is the structure that sells that.

The model

Rather than selling generic ad inventory to any advertiser who'll pay, offer **one advertiser per sector, locked in as the exclusive advertiser across your platform** for an agreed period. A telecom brand that knows it's the *only* telecom advertiser on your platform isn't just buying impressions — it's buying a defensible, differentiated position that's hard to get anywhere else in a cluttered media landscape.

Template: Sector Map

Adapt this list to your market — the specific 30 sectors below are a starting template, not a fixed list:

Telecom · Banking · Fintech · Beverages (alcoholic & non-alcoholic) · Real Estate · Automobile · FMCG (household) · FMCG (personal care) · Insurance · Health Tech · Pharma · Airlines · Travel & Tourism · Beauty · E-commerce · Betting & Gaming · Power & Energy · Logistics · Diaspora Remittance & Money Transfer · Education · Agriculture · Faith-based Organizations · Fashion & Apparel · Sports & Fitness · Media & Entertainment (non-competing) · Government/Public Sector Campaigns · NGO/Development · Automotive Parts & Services · Construction Materials · Consumer Electronics

Template: The Advertiser Pitch (fill-in-the-blank)

"Today, your options for reaching [your target audience — e.g. the African diaspora] are limited and fragmented: [describe current fragmented options]. There is no single platform built to reach that audience continuously, with content they actually choose to watch.

As [Sector]'s exclusive sponsor across [Your Platform]'s full channel lineup, your brand appears consistently, never alongside a direct competitor, embedded in content people are actually watching rather than skipping past. That's a fundamentally different, more defensible media buy than anything currently available in this market."

Negotiation checklist — before you pitch category-exclusive sponsorship

- ☐ Map your actual addressable sectors — don't guess, research which categories have both budget and a genuine reach problem in your market
- ☐ Decide your exclusivity period (quarterly, annual) and what happens at renewal — build in a right-of-first-refusal for renewing sponsors
- ☐ Identify the relevant industry advertising/media buyer associations in your market (in Nigeria: MIPAN, ADVAN, industry experiential/eventing bodies) and plan a direct pitch to them, not just individual brands

- ☐ Prepare a one-page rate card showing what exclusivity costs vs. non-exclusive inventory — exclusivity should carry a real premium, not be priced the same as regular ad spend
 - ☐ Build a simple reporting structure so sponsors can see their exclusivity is being honored (e.g. a monthly report confirming no competing-category ads ran)
 - ☐ Have your content/channel lineup credible enough to justify the pitch — category exclusivity sells reach and differentiation, but only if there's a real audience behind it
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Part 4: Lessons From the Graveyard — A Pre-Launch Self-Audit

Before launching a FAST or streaming platform anywhere trust has been damaged by prior failed platforms, run your own plan through this checklist honestly:

- ☐ **Are we staying pure to our monetization model**, or is there pressure building internally to “pivot to subscription” once revenue is slower than hoped? (This is the single most common cause of African FAST platform audience collapse — going SVOD shrinks the very audience your ad-funded model needs.)
 - ☐ **Is media/content our core business**, or a side initiative of a company whose core competency and patience sits elsewhere (banking, telecom, etc.)? Side initiatives get deprioritized when budgets tighten.
 - ☐ **Have we written payment terms into every content deal**, with a specific day-count, not left to informal understanding?
 - ☐ **Are we defaulting to non-exclusive, territory-limited content deals** so no content owner is betting everything on us?
 - ☐ **Have we proven our model small** (a handful of channels, a focused launch) before committing to a large, public, all-at-once launch?
 - ☐ **Are we genuinely listening to what content owners and industry associations say they need**, even when it's a harder or more expensive structure for us to deliver — or are we defaulting to whatever's easiest for our own cash flow?
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About the Author

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This playbook draws on real, active deal negotiations, genericized to protect commercially sensitive specifics still in progress. Your own numbers, vendors, and market conditions will differ — use these frameworks as a starting structure, not a copy-paste script.

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